Verbal Reference Check Form

Wycombe Abbey School Changzhou. Safer recruitment. Confidential.

Purpose and instructions for the caller

This form records a telephone or video conversation with a referee for any candidate being appointed to a role at the school. It is part of our safer recruitment process: no offer is confirmed until two satisfactory references have been received and at least one has been verified verbally with the referee.

Complete one form per referee. Attach it to the candidate's recruitment file alongside the written reference.

Before the call

- Read the written reference, the application form and the interview notes so you can probe gaps or inconsistencies.
- Locate the referee's contact details independently (school website, main switchboard, LinkedIn or a professional directory). Do not rely only on a number or email supplied by the candidate.
- For the most recent employer the referee must be the Head, Principal or a senior leader with line management responsibility. HR-only references are acceptable for employment dates but not for conduct or safeguarding questions.
- Confirm that the candidate has given consent for us to contact this referee.

During the call

- Introduce yourself, state the role applied for and explain that notes will be kept on file and may be shared with the candidate under data protection law.
- Ask every question in Sections C to E. Record the referee's answers in their own words as far as possible, not your summary of them.
- Do not lead the referee. If an answer is vague, ask a follow-up and note the follow-up.
- Note any hesitation, deflection or reluctance to answer. These are observations, not conclusions, and should be recorded as such.

After the call

- Complete Sections F and G the same day.
- Any concern about safeguarding, conduct or honesty must be escalated to the Executive Headmaster and the Designated Safeguarding Lead before the candidate is informed of the outcome.
- Store the completed form in the confidential recruitment file. Do not keep copies on personal devices or in email.

Section A: Candidate and post details

Field	Entry
Candidate full name (as on passport)	
Any previous names used	
Post applied for	
Department or section	
Proposed start date	
Is this a regulated role with direct contact with pupils?	Yes / No
Is this referee the current or most recent employer?	Yes / No
Written reference received?	Yes / No, date received:
Name of caller	
Role of caller	

Field	Entry
Date and time of call	
Call duration (minutes)	

Section B: Referee details and identity verification

The purpose of this section is to confirm that we are speaking to the person who wrote the reference and that they are who they say they are.

Field	Entry
Referee full name	
Referee job title	
Organisation	
Relationship to candidate (line manager, Head, HR, colleague)	
Period during which referee knew the candidate	From: To:
Contact number used for the call	
How was this number obtained? (switchboard, website, directory, candidate)	
Was the call routed through the organisation's main switchboard?	Yes / No
Does the referee's email domain match the organisation?	Yes / No, domain:
Did the referee confirm they wrote the written reference?	Yes / No
Is the referee the person named on the written reference?	Yes / No

Verification check

☐ Referee's identity and role confirmed independently of the candidate
☐ Referee confirmed authorship of the written reference
☐ Any discrepancy between referee details and written reference recorded below

Discrepancies or notes on verification:

Section C: Employment verification

Check each answer against the application form. Record the referee's answer, then tick whether it matches.

Question	Referee's answer	Matches application?
1. Can you confirm the dates the candidate was employed with you?		Yes / No
2. What was their job title and what did the role involve?		Yes / No
3. Did they hold any additional responsibilities (pastoral, boarding, coordination, line management)?		Yes / No
4. Was the post full time or part time, permanent or fixed term?		Yes / No
5. What was their reason for leaving, or why are they seeking to leave?		Yes / No
6. Were there any gaps in their employment with you (unpaid leave, secondment, suspension)?		Yes / No
7. Was their employment ever subject		

Question	Referee's answer	Matches application?
to a probation extension, capability process or formal improvement plan?		
8. What was their attendance and punctuality like? Any patterns of absence?		

Section D: Performance, conduct and attendance

Ask for examples where possible. A referee who can describe a specific situation is more reliable than one who offers adjectives.

Question	Referee's answer
9. How would you describe the quality of their teaching or professional work? What evidence do you have for that (observations, outcomes, appraisal)?	
10. How did they work with colleagues? Any difficulties in professional relationships?	
11. How did they relate to pupils? How did they manage behaviour and build relationships?	
12. How did they communicate with parents? Were there any parental complaints and how were they handled?	
13. How did they respond to feedback, challenge and change?	
14. Did they follow school policies and procedures reliably (reporting, deadlines, duties, data entry)?	
15. What were their main strengths?	
16. What areas would you identify for development?	
17. Were they ever subject to a formal disciplinary process, warning or grievance (upheld or not)?	
18. Did they have any involvement in co-curricular, boarding or wider school life?	

Rating by referee (optional, ask the referee to score 1 to 5 where 5 is outstanding)

Area	Score (1 to 5)	Referee's comment
Professional competence		
Reliability and integrity		
Relationships with pupils		
Relationships with colleagues		
Relationships with parents		
Suitability for the post applied for		

Section E: Safeguarding and suitability to work with children

Every question in this section must be asked, in full, for every candidate. Read the question as written. Record the answer verbatim where you can. A "no" must be an explicit "no" from the referee, not an absence of comment.

Question	Referee's answer (verbatim where possible)	Asked?
19. Are you aware of any allegations, concerns or complaints that have been made about this person relating to their behaviour towards children or young people?		Yes

Question	Referee's answer (verbatim where possible)	Asked?
20. Have any such allegations or concerns been investigated? What was the outcome?		Yes
21. Have there been any allegations that were found to be unsubstantiated, unfounded, false or malicious? (We ask so that we have the full picture. These should not be included in a written reference but may be discussed.)		Yes
22. Has the candidate ever been subject to a disciplinary process or sanction relating to the safety or welfare of children, including any that have expired?		Yes
23. Were there any concerns about their professional boundaries with pupils, including online, on social media or outside school hours?		Yes
24. Were there any concerns about their conduct in a boarding, residential or trip setting?		Yes
25. Were there any concerns about their use of physical intervention, restraint or sanctions?		Yes
26. Did they complete and keep up to date all required safeguarding training?		Yes
27. Did they comply with your code of conduct and safeguarding policy?		Yes
28. Are you aware of any reason, including anything not covered above, why this person should not work with children?		Yes
29. Did they leave your employment while any investigation or process was ongoing, or in circumstances that would have led to one?		Yes
30. Would you re-employ this person? If not, why not?		Yes

Caller's observations during this section

Record tone, hesitation, requests to go off the record, or any answer that changed when a follow-up question was asked. Observations are not findings and must be worded as such.

Safeguarding flag

☐ No safeguarding or suitability concern raised
☐ Concern raised. Escalated to Executive Headmaster and Designated Safeguarding Lead on (date):

☐ Referee declined to answer one or more questions. Question numbers:

Section F: Consistency check

Compare what the referee said with the written reference, the application form and the interview. Any item marked "No" must be explained in the notes column and followed up with the candidate or referee before an offer is confirmed.

Check	Consistent?	Notes and action taken
Employment dates match application form	Yes / No	
Job title and responsibilities match application form	Yes / No	
Reason for leaving matches what the candidate told us at interview	Yes / No	
Verbal account matches the tone and content of the written reference	Yes / No	
No unexplained gaps between this post and the next or previous one	Yes / No	
Referee's description of strengths and development areas matches interview evidence	Yes / No	
Disciplinary or capability history matches the candidate's self-declaration	Yes / No	
Safeguarding answers match the written reference and the candidate's self-declaration	Yes / No	

Information the referee gave that was not in the written reference

Information in the written reference that the referee could not confirm or contradicted

Section G: Overall judgement and sign-off

Caller's overall assessment (select one)

☐ Satisfactory. No concerns. Reference supports appointment.
☐ Satisfactory with follow-up. Minor inconsistencies to be clarified with the candidate before offer is confirmed. Detail below.
☐ Not satisfactory. Concerns about conduct, suitability or honesty. Escalated. Do not confirm offer.
☐ Unable to complete. Referee could not be reached or declined to participate after three attempts on different days. Alternative referee requested.

Summary of concerns or follow-up actions

Issue	Action required	Owner	Due date	Completed?

Sign-off

Role	Name	Signature	Date
Caller			
Line manager of the post or Head of Section			
HR			
Executive Headmaster (required where any concern is flagged in Section E or G)			

This form is confidential and forms part of the candidate's recruitment record. Retain for the duration of employment plus six years, or in line with the school's records retention schedule, whichever is longer.

Appendix: Call script, record keeping and data protection

Opening the call

> Good morning / afternoon. My name is [name] and I am [role] at Wycombe Abbey School Changzhou. I am calling about [candidate name], who has applied for the post of [post] with us and has given your name as a referee. Thank you for the written reference you provided on [date]. As part of our safer recruitment process we verify all references verbally. The call will take around fifteen to twenty minutes. I will be taking notes, which will be kept on the candidate's confidential recruitment file. Under data protection law the candidate may be entitled to see those notes. Is now a convenient time, and are you happy to proceed on that basis?

If the referee asks to speak off the record

> I am not able to receive information off the record. Anything you tell me will be noted and may be acted upon. If you have a concern about this candidate's suitability to work with children, I would ask you to share it so that we can consider it properly.

Closing the call

> Thank you. Is there anything else you think we should know before appointing [candidate name] to work with our pupils? If anything occurs to you after this call, please contact me directly on [number / email]. I may contact you again if we need to clarify any point.

Record keeping

- Write up notes within 24 hours while the conversation is fresh. Use the referee's words where you recorded them.
- Do not record the call without the referee's explicit consent. Written notes are sufficient.
- Store the completed form, the written reference and any follow-up correspondence together in the confidential recruitment file.
- Where a concern has been raised, the form must also be shared with the Designated Safeguarding Lead and kept with the single central record entry.

Data protection

- Collect only what is needed to assess suitability for the post. Do not ask about health, family circumstances, religion, politics or other matters unrelated to the role.
- References are confidential to the recruitment process. The candidate may request access to their recruitment file; the referee's personal data may be redacted where appropriate.
- Do not forward references or notes by personal email or messaging apps.
- Shred or securely delete working notes once the final form is complete and filed.

If a reference cannot be obtained

- Record each attempt (date, time, method) in Section G.

- After three attempts on different working days, request an alternative referee from the candidate and record why.
- A verbal reference is a condition of appointment. Where it cannot be obtained before the start date, the Executive Headmaster must approve any decision to proceed, and the appointment must be subject to the reference being received and found satisfactory.